

The Word of the Guru

Storyline

INTRODUCTION

(Narration)

Where is happiness? Where is rest from the fever of life? Where is the image of perfection? Where is that luminous something, in which we can live apart and be free -- free from a sense of want and suffering?

These seem to be some of the eternal questions echoing and re-echoing through the ages within the heart of humanity. Some think the answer can be found in material comforts. Some search for the answer in books. Some sit in meditation trying to tune their life-breath in unison with the Great Knowledge, some others scorn delights and live laborious days, all these attain degrees of success.

Once in a hundred years, solitary among a hundred thousand, there arrives at the caravanserai of life one, at the sight of whose features the seekers instinctively arise from their varied occupations and greet him, and see in him and his ways a clear commentary, a silent

interpretation, a radiant center of all that they were seeking, and for a moment feel a strange happiness. Literature and art and science grow round this person. Historical events find a center round which to turn.

Narayana Guru was one of such. He was one of those who followed in his life the ancient and immemorial programme of oriental saints and prophets. Today his words are recognised as a most modern echo of the ancient wisdom of the Orient. In him we had, combined once again, a bard who sang about the aspirations of the soul of man, a philanthropist whose one aim in life, night and day, was to devise ways to minimise human suffering, and a seer whose daily food and drink was the highest form of Truth.

(TITLE)

SRI NARAYANA GURU

(Aum Sahodaryam Sarvatra)

(Aum, Brotherhood Omnipresent Fills!)

The Guru at Home

Alwaye is a small municipal town belonging to the State of Travancore, it is associated with the name of the great Indian philosopher Sankaracarya. If the traveller had directed his footsteps along one of the roads leading to the river-side, he would have come across a stile leading into a compound, which he must cross, keeping his way along the narrow avenue till he reached the bright riverside beyond the trees. He would have found, on turning to the right, a neat little white building strewn round with pure river sand - the silence of the place broken only by birds or by the voices of occasional bathers in the river. If the Guru was in the asrama he could invariably be found on a little raised seat overlooking the river. As he turned to look at the visitor, the latter would, if he had a keen eye, discover from the expression of his face that the Guru had just been disturbed from some all-absorbing subject while he sat gazing the river scene. He would ask the newcomer who he was, in the most gentle of voices; and treat him, probably to a meal of fruits and milk. After that, if he conversed, the topic in all probably turned on how human nature must improve; how there is no necessity for man to quarrel with man, as he does at present, on supposed religious, national, or racial distinctions, how, while a cow

or a dog may be considered to belong to a different 'caste', it is absurd to think that one man differs from another except in trivial things like dress or language; and how it is immaterial in everyday life, what school of philosophy or what creed a man professed so long as he does not transgress the bounds of common human goodness. In the grounds of the hermitage he would have found trees, each one of them receiving its share of the Guru's care. Before leaving the precincts, had the visitor cast his glance on the inscription in golden letters on one of the walls of the asrama, he would have read:

One in kind, one in faith, one in God is man.
Of one same womb, one same form, difference none there
is at all.

Brotherhood

It was a red-letter day in the history of the little asrama at Alwaye, on which was to be celebrated, by some of the enthusiastic young men of the surrounding districts, the anniversary of their association for Universal Brotherhood. On this particular morning it was one of the new young men who had arrived at the hermitage and who had decided to be a worker among the people, who was

standing reverently, talking to the Guru about the meeting that was to take place. The Guru turned his face, with half-wakeful eyelids, towards the optimistic young man and asked him, his voice softened by the peaceful rest of morning meditation. 'Do you think there is any use in holding big meetings?' 'Yes', was the decided reply of the young man, 'meetings are the best means of spreading ideas'. 'But', said the Guru, 'they do not appear to produce as much action as noise. But they may not be completely useless. It is good, all the same, to have some meetings now and then to rouse the public conscience...Can you speak to the crowd?' 'I shall try to', replied the young man humbly. 'It would be a good thing,' continued the Guru, 'to tell them about the excessive human greed. Man is terribly inconsistent. The state, which calls itself interested in humanity, would for example, vehemently forbid even a man suffering from the worst form of skin disease to quit his miserable body. On the other hand, it will madly engage itself in wholesale man-slaughter, after due deliberation and in the holy name of altruism or religion. Man does not know what he does, although he prides himself on being more intelligent than the animals. Speeches should not be made with a spirit of rivalry or hate. All speech is for knowing and letting others know. A man's religion is a matter of his personal conviction, which is bound to be at varying stages of natural evolution in

different people. The Goal is common. Why should man fight for his faith? It is an unwise act - one should not be swayed by the conflict of opinions, but should remain tranquil knowing the Unity in all human effort, which is Happiness.

The Guru disapproved of all imaginary distinctions between man and man -- in which he saw the cause of much unhappiness and unrest. The young men had already made him commit himself to a definite statement about the burning question of caste distinction in India; and the Guru's message was ready to be distributed in the afternoon. It ran as follows:

“Whatever may be the differences in men's creed, dress, language, etc.-- because they belong all to the same kind of creation, there is no harm at all in their dinning together or having marital relations with one another”-- Narayana Guru

The Guru who ‘puzzlingly’ combined and represented the views of the hot-headed young reformers and those of the callous, conservative elders, he sat silently between the two rival parties -- who vied with one another in doing homage to him -- as the personification of the principle of exalting Synthesis. His love for men made him the most

artful and just peacemaker, whilst remaining himself most obstinately uncompromising when occasion demanded.

It was nearing midday. The Guru rose and wended his way to his river-side resting place. On the way he stopped, seeing some boys giving the last touches to the decoration of a triumphal arch through which the delegates were to enter. He suggested that the mystic syllable 'AUM' might be written to decorate the top of the arch: and under it the words *sahodaryam sarvatra*,

'Aum, Brotherhood Omnipresent Fills!'